



There is a parable about two sons in Mt 21:28-32. When Jesus told it he was drawing near the end of his public ministry and earthly existence. He had just been to the temple in Jerusalem where, in righteous anger, he had expelled the money changers and those who were selling animals. His prophetic action was, implicitly, a condemnation of the temple authorities, whose way of acting failed to give due deference to God.

That incident was followed by the symbolic cursing of a fig-tree. It was to be understood as a symbol of the Jewish people. They bore the outward leaves of religious observance, while failing to bear the expected fruit of repentance and obedience to the word and will of God. As a result, they were cursed like the fig-tree to wither and die. The curse came to fulfilment with the destruction of Jerusalem and its temple in AD 70.

The parable of the two sons was about differing responses to Jesus and his message. According to St John Chrysostom's commentary, the two sons represented Jews and Gentiles: the former, having heard the Old Testament law and promised obedience, were disobedient, while the latter, not

having heard the Old Testament law, became obedient to Christ once they heard his message. Modern scripture scholars, however, have begun to question that interpretation. They maintain that the parable is about different responses to John the Baptist. The father represented God; the first son represented tax collectors, prostitutes, and those who were lax in the observance of the law. However, they came to obey God as a result of John the Baptist's ministry. The second son represented the chief priests and the temple authorities, those who, despite their religious profession, disobeyed God by not believing in John.

This parable is reminiscent of the one about the prodigal son in Lk 15:11-32. The younger son, who represented outcasts and sinners, started out refusing to obey his father or to work for him, but finally, following many vicissitudes, he complied. The older son, who represented the scribes and Pharisees, insisted that he had worked for and obeyed his father, but in the final analysis he turned against him as a result of envy and resentment. In the last analysis, it was the younger son, in contrast to his elder brother who ended up in a loving union with his father. ■

— Pat Collins

THE COMMUNION RITE

At the Saviour's command ...

Our Father, who art in heaven, ...

Deliver us, Lord, we pray, from every evil, ...

**For the kingdom,
the power and the glory are yours
now and for ever.**

Lord Jesus Christ, ...

Amen.

The peace of the Lord be with you always.

And with your spirit.

Lamb of God, you take away the sins ...

Behold the Lamb of God, ...

Lord, I am not worthy

that you should enter under my roof,

**but only say the word
and my soul shall be healed.**

Communion Antiphon (Cf. Ps 118:49-50)

Remember your word to your servant,

O Lord,

by which you have given me hope.

This is my comfort when I am brought low.

Prayer after Communion

May this heavenly mystery, O Lord,

restore us in mind and body,

that we may be coheirs in glory with Christ,

to whose suffering we are united

whenever we proclaim his Death.

Who lives and reigns for ever and ever. **Amen.**



Reflection

Prayerfully consider the parable of the willing son and the rebellious son and link it with your own life.



Lesson

Our God is always one for a second chance.



Prayer

Lord, turn our hearts to you and guide us through repentance to the joy of your kingdom.

